

time an overzealous teacher will present principles as if they were laws. They are not. A principle is an instruction from the Lord to help guide our decisions. A law is an absolute. Negative consequences may follow from ignoring a principle, but punishment is the likely consequence of ignoring a law God has given us.

An example from our society is drinking and driving. A good guideline, or principle, to follow is never to drink. But the law says that if you drink and drive, you can lose your license and perhaps go to jail.

The principle of borrowing given in Scripture is that it is better not to provide security for a loan. “A man lacking in judgment strikes hands in pledge and puts up security for his neighbor” (Proverbs 17:18). If your neighbor—or friend or family member—is unable to pay the debt, you are responsible for it.

The law of borrowing given in Scripture is that it is a sin to borrow and not repay. “The wicked borrow and do not repay, but the righteous give generously” (Psalm 37:21). The assumption in the verse is that the wicked person can repay but will not, as opposed to an individual who wants to repay but cannot.

Principles are given to keep us clearly within God’s path so that we can experience His blessings. To ignore them puts us in a constant state of jeopardy in which Satan can cause us to stumble at any time.

1: Debt is not the norm

Regardless of how it seems today, debt is not the norm in any economy and should not be the norm for God’s people. We live in a debt-ridden society that is now virtually dependent on a constant expansion of credit to keep the economy going. That is a symptom of a society no longer willing to follow God’s principles. We see this disobedience in many areas, so why should we assume it is any different in the area of money? Yet Christians who would never think of actively participating in a lifestyle of sinful behavior naively follow the world’s path in the area of credit.